

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 83

By Chism

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of William J. Chism, Sr.

WHEREAS, we were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of William J. Chism, Sr., a beloved gentleman and family patriarch whose legacy of integrity, hard work, and spiritual commitment will continue to inspire others; and

WHEREAS, born on July 16, 1944, in Hubert, Arkansas, William Chism was the first child born to Ray and Dorothy Chism; he professed his hope in Christ and was baptized at New Salem Church in West Memphis, Arkansas, where his father and uncle, James "Buddy" Chism, served as deacons; and

WHEREAS, a standout football player at Melrose High School, Mr. Chism was awarded the prestigious title of "The Gridiron Greatest," which recognized him as the top football player in Memphis, and local radio station WDIA honored his athletic prowess with a gold watch; and

WHEREAS, William Chism served his country as a member of the United States Army, and he worked at Armor Meat Packing before joining his three brothers, who had ventured into the retail grocery business, a fortuitous endeavor that resulted in several stores operating under the moniker "Chism Trail"; and

WHEREAS, together, the Chism brothers built the largest Black-owned supermarket chain in Tennessee history; in addition to their retail success, they served as the building contractors for many of the commercial buildings where they operated, solidifying their influence in Memphis; and

WHEREAS, under the Chism Trail flagship, the family business employed hundreds of individuals in the community, as many as 300 people at its peak, cultivating a culture of

entrepreneurship and business acumen and empowering future generations to pursue their own paths to success; and

WHEREAS, William Chism was also a lover of the outdoors and a true cowboy at heart, earning him the nickname "Wild Bill"; he owned and rode horses, built a barn in the backyard of his Memphis home in Lakeview Gardens, and bought a farm where he and his sons spent time connecting with nature; and

WHEREAS, a man of abiding faith throughout his lifetime, Mr. Chism served as a deacon at Mt. Bethel Church, sang background with his father in the Magnolia Specials, and attended Mt. Vernon Baptist Church with his wife in later years; and

WHEREAS, he was also wholly devoted to his family and was revered as the Chism family patriarch, leading by example through wisdom, accountability, strength, and purpose and inspiring his progeny to greatness; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Chism is survived by his wife of forty-seven years, Norma; children, Angela, William, Jr., Stephanie, Jesse, Justin, and Jerome; thirteen grandchildren; four great-grandchildren; ten siblings; and a host of nieces and nephews; and

WHEREAS, throughout his many endeavors in both public and private life, William Chism distinguished himself as a devoted family man who served his community in myriad ways; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that we should pay tribute to his bountiful life of purpose and commitment; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of William J. Chism, Sr., reflecting fondly upon his enduring legacy in Memphis and beyond.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we extend our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family and loved ones of Mr. Chism.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.